SEPTEMBER 5, 2016

TIME

Ordinary Families. Extraordinary Kids.

A story of nine families

By Charlotte Alter

time.com

TIME Magazine

[September 5th, 2016]

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The Secrets of Super Siblings

Charlotte Alter is a senior correspondent at TIME. She covers politics, social movements, and generational change, and hosts TIME's Person of the Week podcast. She is also the author of *The Ones We've Been Waiting For: How a New Generation of Leaders Will Transform America*. Her work for TIME has won a Front Page Award from the Newswoman's Club of New York and has been nominated for a GLAAD Media award.

Every night for 20 years, Gino Rodriguez knelt beside his three daughters' beds and whispered an incantation. As rats the size of footballs skittered along the floor of the basement apartment on the South Side of Chicago, he repeated the same five words into each girl's ear as she slept: "I can and I will." The message was always the same, and the audience was always asleep…

Read the full story at time.com/superfamilies.

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India’s Economic Engine Has a Rocky Road Ahead

Ian Bremmer is a foreign affairs columnist and editor-at-large at TIME. He is the president of Eurasia Group, a political-risk consultancy, and GZERO Media, a company dedicated to providing intelligent and engaging coverage of international affairs. He teaches applied geopolitics at Columbia University’s School of International and Public Affairs, and his most recent book is The Power of Crisis.

Since 2014, India has been the emerging-market world’s most positive story. That’s mainly because Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) have cut red tape to make it easier to do business in this historically closed country. Modi’s government has lowered barriers to foreign investment and dramatically simplified the tax system. India’s economy has taken off, with growth forecast at 7.8% this year.

Yet this is probably the last major piece of positive reform news we’ll hear from India for the next couple of years. There are two crucial proposals that aren’t going anywhere until after the next national elections, in 2019. First, change is needed to create a much more flexible labor force. Laws meant to protect workers make it extremely difficult to fire employees in tough times, which makes it harder to persuade companies to hire new workers when times are good. Second, badly needed infrastructure projects remain on hold across the country because it’s difficult to secure land rights. These issues create an artificial limit on job creation in a country where 1 million new entrants join the workforce each month.

Modi’s government can’t move forward on labor or land reform when it faces more than a dozen state elections in 2017 and 2018.

He knows the opposition Congress Party and the anticorruption Aam Aadmi Party will accuse the BJP of favoring Big Business at the expense of workers and farmers.

To protect his party's vote share, Modi is seeking populist causes. Unfortunately, this strategy has begun with a much tougher attitude toward Pakistan. The killing of a popular Muslim militant has set off a round of violence in India's Jammu and Kashmir state. Indian and Pakistani officials have faced off over the unrest, and Modi has raised tensions by criticizing Pakistan's government. Progress toward better relations is off the table for now.

In addition, a resurgence of Hindu nationalism is raising tensions inside India. Modi's BJP rose to power in 2014 on promises of "minimum government, maximum governance." Fed up with a stagnant economy and a Congress Party government beset by corruption, many people from lower castes and socially liberal upper classes set aside concerns about the BJP's traditional Hindu nationalism to back the party. Yet debates over caste, religion and country are making a comeback, with fiery confrontations between backers and critics of the BJP on university campuses stirring protests.

Modi has accomplished a lot, and India remains a mostly positive story. But the pace of progress is about to slow, and ghosts from the past are now circling overhead.

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We’re Working Harder Than Ever, So Why Is Productivity Plummeting?

Most of us feel more productive than ever. Between wi-fi and mobile data, smartphones and apps that let us do everything from hail a ride to order groceries, we can get more done, in more places, more of the time—whether we want to or not. So why does the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) keep telling us that’s an illusion? Not only is productivity in America declining, but it’s been falling for over a decade. Even during the booming mid-2000s, according to the government’s statisticians, productivity began to flatten and fall. Since economic growth is the product of productivity and demographics, the BLS numbers are a big deal. With birthrates falling and immigration down, productivity needs to go up—or we’ll soon be worse off economically than our parents.

The slowdown in productivity is now widely seen as one of the big factors in America’s tepid economic recovery. (The U.S. is not alone here: the number of other countries growing by less than 2% a year has been steadily rising over the past few years, as productivity decreases.) Why is productivity down? Theories range

from the retirement of highly skilled baby boomers to a lack of productivity-enhancing investment by private companies to a failure to correctly measure productivity itself.

[video id=FiRS8pAm]

One of the most provocative reasons has been put forward by Northwestern University's Robert Gordon in a new book, *The Rise and Fall of American Growth*. According to Gordon, the digital-technology boom just isn't all it's been cracked up to be—especially when compared with world-beating shifts like indoor plumbing, electricity and the combustion engine. Gordon is fast becoming this year's Thomas Piketty when it comes to both intellectual buzz and sheer book size—like Piketty's 2013 *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, which chronicled income inequality, Gordon's work is a 700-page-plus doorstop.

But in a nutshell, Gordon argues that the Industrial Revolution at the turn of the 19th century had a much bigger effect on economic growth than the PC revolution in the 20th. He points out that productivity growth actually began shrinking after the 1970s, when digital technology really began to take off. Gordon says the big productivity payoff from digital technology has already come and gone, concentrated mostly from 1996 to 2004. "You've got some productivity-growth effect filtering through from the use of smartphones and tablets, but not nearly as much as from the PC boom," he says.

[video id=j2LHstLg]

Some tech proponents have theorized that productivity is not being counted correctly. They argue that the BLS is still too focused on the production of physical goods, missing some hard-to-count benefits of the digital revolution. But a recent study from the Fed and the IMF debunks this notion somewhat. Even if technology's benefits are being undermeasured, official productivity numbers

briefly rose during the early Internet boom and have continued to dip since.

That leaves many wondering about the role of corporate investment in the economy. It's a well-known fact that many companies have hoarded cash or paid out money to investors in the form of share buybacks and dividends over the past decade, rather than investing in research and development. While underinvestment in new technologies that help workers become more productive accounts for only about one-third of the productivity drop, the lack of investment via R&D in the next New New Thing—whatever it may turn out to be—is a more nebulous thing to tally.

What we know for sure is that America's biggest run-up in productivity happened from 1945 to 1973, when there were major public and private investments in education, infrastructure and worker training. Similar investments, which have been proposed by Democratic presidential candidate Hillary Clinton, could also have the effect (as they did then) of raising wages, which would bolster demand, giving companies more reason to invest—creating a virtuous cycle of productivity growth, wage growth and economic growth.

Certainly, most experts feel that it's time for politicians, rather than bankers, to take a lead on the productivity issue. As Federal Reserve vice-chair Stanley Fisher said in a speech recently, "monetary policy is not well equipped to address long-term issues like the slowdown in productivity growth. Rather, the key to boosting productivity growth, and the long-run potential of the economy, is more likely to be found in effective fiscal and regulatory policies." Translation: the next president, and more particularly Congress, need to capitalize on the opportunity that the Federal Reserve has provided by keeping rates so low, for so long. After all bankers, even central bankers, can't manufacture real growth–only provide the environment in which it might thrive.

There is one bit of good news: nobody is suggesting that productivity isn’t rising because individuals aren’t working hard enough. On the contrary, most economists believe that American blue and white collar workers alike are firing on all cylinders. What we need are new tools and training to make the work that we do count more. That will ultimately require technologies that take us far beyond online taxi ordering, food delivery and the latest gaming app.

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What Donald Trump Knew About Undocumented Workers at His Signature Tower

Massimo Calabresi is TIME's Washington bureau chief.

In the summer of 1980, Donald Trump faced a big problem. For six months, undocumented Polish laborers had been clearing the future site of Trump Tower, his signature real estate project on Manhattan’s Fifth Avenue, where he now lives, maintains his private offices and hosts his presidential campaign.

The men were putting in 12-hour shifts with inadequate safety equipment at subpar wages that their contractor paid sporadically, if at all. A lawyer for many of the Poles demanded that the workers be paid or else he would serve Trump with a lien on the property. One Polish worker even went to Trump’s office to ask him for money in person, according to sworn testimony and a deposition filed under oath in a court case.

For help, Trump turned to Daniel Sullivan, a 6-ft. 5-in., 285-lb. labor consultant, FBI informant and future officer of the Teamsters Union. “Donald told me he had difficulties …,” Sullivan later testified in the case. “That he had some illegal Polish employees on the job.”

[video id=ZnrBU8IB]

Sullivan had been helping Trump negotiate a casino deal in New Jersey at the time, and he testified that he was shocked by Trump’s admission. “I think you are nuts,” Sullivan testified that he told Trump. “You are here negotiating a lease in Atlantic City for a casino license and you are telling me you have got illegal employees on the job.”

For 36 years, Trump has denied knowingly using undocumented workers to demolish the building that would be replaced with Trump Tower in 1980. After Senator Marco Rubio raised the issue of undocumented Polish workers during a Republican primary debate this year, Trump described himself as removed from the problem. “I hire a contractor. The contractor then hires the subcontractor,” he said. “They have people. I don’t know. I don’t remember, that was so many years ago, 35 years ago.”

But thousands of pages of documents from the case, including reams of testimony and sworn depositions reviewed by TIME, tell a different story. Kept for more than a decade in 13 boxes in a federal judiciary storage unit in Missouri, the documents contain testimony that Trump sought out the Polish workers when he saw them on another job, instigated the creation of the company that paid them and negotiated the hours they would work. The papers contain testimony that Trump repeatedly toured the site where the men were working, directly addressed them about pay problems and even promised to pay them himself, which he eventually did.

The documents show that after things got ugly over unpaid wages, Trump sought Sullivan's advice on the workers and their immigration status. At one point, a lawyer for the Poles testified, Trump threatened, through his own lawyer, to call the Immigration and Naturalization Service and have the workers deported. And when the Labor Department launched a probe of the Polish laborers, Trump again called Sullivan for help, asking him to meet the federal investigator at Trump's office, according to the documents.

Testifying at a 1990 trial where he faced a charge of participation in a breach of fiduciary duty, Trump told a federal judge he "still didn't know" if the workers were undocumented, arguing that he had hired a subcontractor who employed them and that he personally "wasn't very involved in that whole process." His lawyers also questioned the credibility of Sullivan, who had been convicted of tax evasion in a separate case. When contacted Aug. 23 by TIME for comment on the documents, Trump replied with an emailed statement. "The laws were totally different thirty five years ago," he wrote in the message. "The building, Trump Tower, turned out to be one of the most successful and iconic buildings ever built. Do you have nothing better to write about than a story that is 35 years old and filled with half truths and false information?"

Later that day, as part of a political pivot designed to soften his image with minority and centrist voters, Trump told an interviewer he might reconsider the hard-line stance against undocumented immigrants that has been a centerpiece of his campaign. Since shortly after launching his bid for the presidency, he has promised to rid the nation of its 11 million undocumented workers, possibly by employing a "deportation force," and to suspend issuing new green cards in order to force employers to hire from the citizen labor pool. He has regularly described undocumented workers as an economic threat to U.S. citizens. "They're taking our

manufacturing jobs," he said at a rally in Phoenix in July 2015. "They're taking our money. They're killing us."

Thirty-six years ago, at the beginning of his career, he saw things differently.

Trump Tower has never been just another building project for Donald Trump. And in 1980, it was something of a personal obsession. He had started in real estate in Queens, working for his father, who had prospered in the outer boroughs. In 1979 he managed, through charm, persistence and hard work, to secure the lease on the old Bonwit Teller building at 56th Street and Fifth Avenue, eventually signing a 50-50 deal with the property owner to develop what would be the city's tallest glass structure on the site. Facing zoning restrictions, Trump made large donations to politicians and curried favor with powerful members of the New York board of estimate, which approved a zoning variance for the project.

With the approvals in hand, Trump set about preparing to build. One day in late 1979, he was inspecting renovation work being undertaken by a tenant in a building he owned next door to the site, and saw the Poles at work, according to testimony given to the court by the foreman overseeing the job. The foreman testified that Trump personally approached him to ask who they were. "Those Polish guys are good, hard workers," court documents say the foreman recalled Trump saying. Soon afterward, Trump met with the workers' boss, a man named William Kaszycki, at Trump's lavish office across Fifth Avenue, Kaszycki later testified.

Kaszycki's company specialized in window and job-site cleaning and had never done the heavy demolition work required to remove a 12-story building in midtown Manhattan. Kaszycki testified that Trump told him to start a new company to do the demolition work and directed him to get new and different insurance for the job. Kaszycki, who has since died, testified that he accepted Trump's

$775,000 fee offer flat out. And with Trump offering an additional $25,000 if the building came down quickly, Kaszycki promised him that the Poles would work day and night, seven days a week.

And they did. From January to March 1980, they sneaked over from the job next door and worked two shifts, one from 6 a.m. to 6 p.m., the other from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m. Some later testified that they worked 24-hour shifts. They were paid $4 to $5 an hour, court documents show, which at the time was less than half the prevailing union wage and just above the state minimum wage of $3.10 an hour. Tearing down walls, cutting pipes and pulling electrical wires is dangerous work, and unlike union workers who later joined the job, most of the Polish workers lacked safety equipment like hard hats, according to the testimony of several former workers. A large piece of steel fell on the arm of one worker, Albin Lipinski, breaking several bones and permanently disfiguring his fingers.

But it was a dispute about money, not safety and long hours, that would later cause Trump so much trouble. Five miles east of the Fifth Avenue job site, at a two-story tin-sided house in the heavily Polish neighborhood of Maspeth, Queens, a middle-aged lawyer named John Szabo started getting visits in March 1980 from undocumented Polish laborers who said they were not being paid for their work. Before long, he would have dozens of clients from the same job. Szabo contacted Kaszycki, who was spending much of his time in Florida, but couldn’t reach him. So in late March, Szabo called Thomas Macari, a vice president in Trump’s operation, according to Szabo’s testimony. Macari, who could not be reached for comment, was overseeing the demolition job on a daily basis, according to the testimony of the Poles, Kaszycki and others in the case. If his clients weren’t paid, Szabo said, he would serve Trump with a mechanic’s lien, a powerful legal device that gives a laborer partial claim to the title of a property on which he has worked.

Soon Trump, who toured the site on multiple occasions, according to the testimony of witnesses, had to address the issue himself. One evening in the spring of 1980, he met with some of the workers at the Bonwit Teller building, according to the testimony of one of the Poles on the job, Joseph Dabrowski. Kaszycki hadn't been showing up on the job, and the Poles were angry about not being paid. Trump told them that if Kaszycki left the job for good, he would pay them himself, Dabrowski testified. And initially he made good on that promise. Trump used a bank account that required his signature to pay Kaszycki's creditors, and Macari opened a new account requiring his own signature to pay the demolition workers. Macari paid the Polish workers cash for Trump, according to the sworn testimony of multiple witnesses.

But still the Polish workers were paid inconsistently. Lipinski, who had become a foreman after his arm was crushed by the steel beam, took matters into his own hands. Around noon one afternoon, he walked across Fifth Avenue and into Trump's office, Lipinski testified. "He spoke to the secretary and was surprised the secretary let him speak to Trump," Lipinski's son Jozef says in an interview this summer, sitting next to his father in his apartment in New York. Jozef says his father told him and his brother the story throughout their childhood: "Trump told him, 'I paid the checks and anything I owed to the other guy, and he's supposed to pay you.'"

Now 80, Albin Lipinski is a U.S. citizen. Speaking through an interpreter at his home, he displayed his hand, still scarred from the accident, but says he supports Trump for President. Twenty-seven years after signing an affidavit about his meeting with Trump and testifying under oath about it, he now says he did go to Trump's office but never met Trump. "I went to the office because I was mad I wasn't being paid," he says through a translator, but "I never met Trump." Jozef and his brother say their father has begun forgetting things in his old age.

By early June 1980, the Polish workers' unpaid wages totaled over $100,000. It was at this point, Sullivan later testified, that Trump asked the labor consultant for advice about the laborers. "I told him to fire them promptly if he had any brains," Sullivan testified. Sullivan died in 1993.

Trump initially ignored the advice. On June 27, 1980, the Poles' lawyer, Szabo, went to Trump's office and served Trump with a mechanic's lien, Szabo testified. Worse, the Polish workers were threatening violence, according to Sullivan's testimony. "Donald called me at my home in Pennsylvania on June 27th, 1980, and asked could he see me immediately," Sullivan testified. "He needed some help because the employees on the Bonwit Teller were threatening to hang a fellow named Tom Macari off the building and would I come to New York as soon as possible."

At his office on Fifth Avenue the next day, Trump told Sullivan he was in a bind: if he didn't have the Bonwit building down by Sept. 1, he said, he was going to have to pay real estate taxes on it, Sullivan testified. Sullivan persuaded Trump to fire the Poles and rely only on union workers to get the building down.

Worried the Poles would never get paid, Szabo put a second and third lien on the property. On Aug. 8, he called Macari and told him that because Trump had been paying the Poles, he was legally their employer. That meant that under the Fair Labor Standards Act, Trump couldn't sell any space in the tower until Szabo's clients were paid.

Forty-five minutes later, Szabo testified, he received a call from a man who identified himself as a Mr. Barron from Trump's legal department, who said Trump was going to sue Szabo for $100 million for wrongful filing of mechanic's liens. At trial, Trump admitted that both he and a senior executive at the company had used the name Barron as a pseudonym. "I believe I occasionally used that name," said Trump. But in this case, Macari said under

oath that it had been he who called Szabo while posing as Barron; Szabo testified he didn't recognize "Barron's" voice.

Szabo wrote a long letter defending his actions and laying out his case under the law and sent it to "Barron" on Aug. 18. A few days later, Szabo testified, he received a call from a real lawyer for Trump, Irwin Durben, who said Trump was threatening to ask the Immigration and Naturalization Service to have the Poles deported.

By the fall, the Labor Department was investigating Trump and Kaszycki's use of the undocumented workers. That winter, a Labor Department official made an appointment to inspect Trump's employment records at the office across from the work site. Trump called Sullivan and asked him to attend the meeting with the federal investigator, according to Sullivan's testimony. In the end, Szabo and the Labor Department won a judgment of $254,523.59 against Kaszycki. Trump never had to pay the Poles another cent.

None of this history would have been preserved at the federal court storage facility near Kansas City, Mo., but for a separate fight over money and Trump's use of the Polish workers. According to the contract Kaszycki had signed with Local 95 of the House Wreckers Union, he and Trump were supposed to pay into the union's pension and welfare fund a percentage of every man-hour worked on the project, whether it was done by union or nonunion workers.

A dissident member of Local 95, a former boxer named Harry Diduck, who has since died, realized Trump and Kaszycki had been paying the pension fund only for the hours the few dozen union workers had put in, not for the hours the Poles had worked. In 1983, Diduck and his lawyers, Burton Hall and Wendy Sloan, sued Kaszycki, the union president and subsequently Trump and others for the $600,000 they claimed Trump and his partners owed the pension fund.

Over time, Sloan amassed thousands of pages of testimony from the Polish workers, Sullivan, Szabo, Macari and dozens of others. Trump fought her at every step. When she tried to depose him, he stormed out after two hours complaining that he was being harassed, necessitating a court order forcing another deposition. The case ran for 15 years. The initial judge in the matter found that Trump had participated in defrauding the union pension fund. It then went through an appeal and multiple battles back at the district court under three different judges. Finally, in 1998, when the question of whether Trump was the legal employer of the Poles was set to go to a jury trial, Trump settled. No one knows how much he ended up paying to compensate the union pension fund. The deal remains sealed by the court. TIME and the Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press have asked the court to make the deal public.

But the other records in the case have been sitting in storage ever since. They include a ruling by the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Second Circuit in New York City that gave both sides partial victories. It began with a swipe at the union president and the later complicity of Trump's organization: "This case illustrates an immutable law with respect to falsehoods–as immutable as the one respecting gravity Sir Isaac Newton conceived upon seeing an apple fall from a tree: having first manufactured a falsehood, a person is forced to invent more to maintain it; yet, as here, in the end, time generally reveals what a falsehood hopes to hide."

Sullivan put it more bluntly in 1990 to People magazine. "It was disgusting how he used people," Sullivan said. "I said, 'Don't exploit them like that. Don't try to f-ck these poor souls over.' It baffled me then, and it makes me sick even now that he knowingly had these Poles there for the purpose of Trump Tower at starvation wages. He couldn't give a sh-t because he's Donald Trump and everybody is here to serve him. Over time he became more and

more monstrous and arrogant. I asked myself, ‘How long is it going to take for all of this to catch up with him?’”

–With reporting by MERRILL FABRY and CELINE WOJTALA/NEW YORK and MELISSA AUGUST/WASHINGTON

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Donald Glover Doesn’t Care What You Think Anymore

Eliana Dockterman is a correspondent at TIME. She covers culture, society, and gender, including topics from blockbuster movies to the #MeToo movement to how the pandemic pushed moms out of the workplace.

“*Atlanta* is a Trojan horse,” says Donald Glover, the creator and star of the dramedy, which premieres Sept. 6 on FX. The show is ostensibly about an Ivy League dropout and new dad (Glover) who helps his cousin launch a rap career. But in reality, it’s a bold exploration of race and class that feels like nothing else on television—partly because the writers are all black, as are the stars. *Read more here*

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Sexism Is Over? Give Me a Break.

Susanna Schrobsdorff writes the *It's Not Just You* newsletter on Substack

Here's a number that might come as a surprise: According to a Pew Research survey released in August, most American men—56%—think sexism is over and done with. More than half believe that "the obstacles that once made it harder for women than men to get ahead are now largely gone." As in disappeared. Past tense. Ancient history.

Of course, most women—63%—disagree. So might anyone who has been paying attention to the details emerging from the lawsuits and allegations from women currently and formerly at the Fox News network. One plaintiff described an environment run like a "sex-fueled, Playboy Mansion-like cult" under former Fox chairman Roger Ailes, who resigned in July amid accusations of sexual harassment and suggestions that he fostered an atmosphere

where women were judged by looks and pliability and where men weren't judged much at all.

The Fox News suits and settlements will drag on, and we'll hear more stories that make us want to skip ahead 100 years to some point where this primitive behavior is considered … primitive. But the network's scandal is hardly the worst story of the summer when it comes to women in the workplace. Consider the National Park Service, which celebrated its 100th birthday as "America's best idea" while dealing with a sexual-misconduct crisis. Women reported being groped and propositioned by male National Park Service employees on trips into the parks, and if they rejected the advances, they were subject to verbal abuse and other kinds of bullying. The practice is apparently so widespread that Secretary of the Interior Sally Jewell admitted in July on NPR that the allegations that have surfaced are likely only the "tip of the iceberg." "For many of us who've been in the workplace for a long time, we've experienced some form of sexual harassment," she said, "hazing rights of passage that have made us really uncomfortable."

It's no better at the local firehouse. This summer a number of fire departments are coping with allegations that the few women in their ranks are routinely bullied and harassed. After a young Virginia firefighter hanged herself earlier this year, the Fairfax County fire department began looking into lewd and misogynistic messages posted by her colleagues on an online forum. Other female firefighters across the country have reported that they've had their shampoo bottles filled with urine, semen put on their bunks and holes cut in their clothing. As a result of such behavior, fire departments have paid out hundreds of thousands of dollars to women in the past five years, but changing the firehouse culture remains a challenge.

Then there's the softer side of sexism. The Summer Olympics are always a test—for both the competing athletes and the captive

viewers who must contend with commentators who compared U.S. gold-medal gymnasts to girls hanging out at the mall or who credited a Hungarian swimmer's coach-husband for her world-record-breaking win. We could dismiss the fuss over those verbal slights as political correctness. They're just words, after all, not physical harassment or predatory behavior.

But words matter too, as Sam Polk, a former Wall Street bond trader, pointed out recently in the New York *Times*. Polk wrote an op-ed arguing that the way men talk among themselves about women has a tangible effect on how women are treated at work. He notes that men bond by objectifying women, often referring to them as objects. As in: "I'd like to get behind that." It's hard to imagine calling someone that in any other context: "That is going to the store." But speaking out could be a career killer, so the boys' club is perpetuated. "When you create a culture where women are casually torn apart in conversation," Polk writes, "how can you ever stomach promoting them, or working for them?"

One early benefit of the Fox scandal is that it may encourage other women to come forward. According to a 2015 *Cosmopolitan* survey, 71% of women said they did not file complaints about sexual harassment, likely because they feared appearing difficult or "too sensitive." And they worry about retaliation and job security. Donald Trump suggested in July that his daughter Ivanka would never put up with sexual harassment—she'd just find another career or another company. But it's a lot easier to be tough if you don't need the job.

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The New Transplant Revolution

For four years, Thomas Manning felt like the unluckiest guy in Massachusetts. His misfortune began on a winter afternoon in 2012, when the then 60-year-old bank courier slipped on black ice and a dolly full of packages crashed onto his groin.

At Massachusetts General Hospital, where he was taken for treatment, things became even worse: a doctor examined him and found a lump on his penis. “He looked at me and said, ‘You have cancer,’” Manning says. Following a biopsy, doctors confirmed that Manning was one of the roughly 2,000 U.S. men to be diagnosed each year with penile cancer. To stop the cancer from spreading, his penis would have to be amputated.

Manning’s life changed overnight. He could no longer go to the bathroom standing up, he was out of work for months while recovering from surgery, and even though he was interested in finding a girlfriend, he couldn’t imagine throwing himself back into the dating pool. “What guy is going to go out and date with this kind of injury?” he says.

Faced with the intolerable, Manning asked his doctor for the unimaginable. “My doctor thought I was crazy, but I never stopped asking about the possibility of a penis transplant,” he says. “They amputated my penis, and I wanted it back. It was pretty much that simple.”

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By early May 2016, Manning’s doctors had some good news: He was about to become the first man in the U.S. to receive a penis transplant. Just two other such surgeries have ever been attempted: a 2006 surgery in China that was a failure–doctors said the transplanted penis was removed because of a “severe psychological problem of the recipient and his wife”–and the other in South Africa, on a man who reportedly went on to father a child.

Manning’s lead surgeons, Dr. Curtis Cetrulo and Dr. Dicken Ko, had been practicing on cadavers and applying to the hospital’s internal review board for 3½ years in preparation. Ultimately, it took seven surgeons, six residents and more than 30 other staff members to complete Manning’s 15-hour surgery, sewing onto Manning’s groin the arteries, veins, nerves, urethra and flesh of a deceased man’s penis. Sexual function will return, if all goes well, within a few months. “We are cautiously optimistic about that,” says Cetrulo.

The groundbreaking procedure received by Manning (pictured right) is part of a sweeping and controversial shift in the field of organ transplantation. No longer are doctors solely performing transplants that save lives; they’re increasingly venturing into the territory of so-called quality-of-life transplants: the ones that stand to dramatically improve them.

These astounding surgeries could give burn victims new faces, give hands and other appendages to people who've lost them to illness or in battle, give women born without a uterus the opportunity to bear children. (Doctors in China and Italy are also considering the possibility of a head transplant down the line.) But they also raise complicated ethical questions about whether these surgeries, which are still very much experimental, are worth the significant long-term risks and financial costs they come with.

Penis transplants are estimated to cost $50,000 to $75,000, a uterus transplant is estimated to range from $150,000 to over $500,000, and a face transplant can cost up to $1 million. As of now, hospitals are largely footing the bills–this is research for them, after all–and in some cases, the physicians are volunteering their time. Since the procedures are experimental, they are not yet covered by insurance.

These surgeries are lauded as major breakthroughs, but they also venture into uncharted territory. Powerful, potentially toxic drugs are required for all transplant recipients in order to ensure that the body lives harmoniously with its new tissue. Those drugs put the people who get the transplants at a higher risk for heart disease, serious infections and a shorter lifespan. People must often take the drugs forever. For now, Manning takes multiple drugs every single day.

Manning will turn 65 in December and says he felt he had nothing to lose. "I am an older guy. How long am I going to be around?" he says. "It's better they try this on me than try it on some kid who's 25."

It's been more than 60 years since the first successful organ transplant–a kidney–and in the intervening years, scientists have done what scientists do: learn from one experiment in order to conduct ever more sophisticated follow-ups. That kidney was followed by the first successful liver transplant, in 1967, followed the next year by the first successful heart transplant. Those

surgeries have become standard care for people who need them, but like the new crop of surgeries, they carry some risk. Some argue that the difference between the two is that you can't live without a heart, whereas you can, technically, live without a penis. But because these newer surgeries can be life-and mental-health-enhancing, they're slowly growing in acceptance and frequency.

These types of transplants are called vascularized composite allografts (VCAs). That means they include the transplantation of multiple tissues like skin, blood vessels, muscles, nerves, bone and connective tissue. In 2014, the U.S. government announced that VCAs–which include penises, uteruses, hands, faces and limbs–would be treated like any other organ, and Americans could be put on a national waiting list for them.

Before that, hospitals worked directly with local organ-procurement groups to identify a possible match. Since 1999, when the first hand transplant in the U.S. was performed, there have been 42 VCA procedures in the U.S., including 11 face transplants, 17 single hand or arm transplants and 11 double hand or arm transplants.

The field of nonlifesaving organ and tissue transplants is still nascent, but it reached a turning point in the past year. In August 2015, doctors at NYU's Langone Medical Center accomplished a groundbreaking feat–the most complete face transplant ever performed–on a volunteer firefighter named Patrick Hardison, 42, of Senatobia, Miss., whose fire-burned face was reconstructed with the face of a deceased cyclist. A month earlier, an 8-year-old boy became the first child to receive a double hand transplant after an illness in infancy required double amputation. In February 2016, doctors at the Cleveland Clinic performed the first uterus transplant in the U.S., and Manning made history with his penis surgery in May 2016.

There is a price for going first: not all these procedures have gone according to plan. Jeff Kepner, the recipient of the first ever double hand transplant in the U.S., in 2009, says his hands have never worked and he'd like them removed so he can use prostheses instead, but he doesn't want to endure additional surgeries. "I can do absolutely nothing," he says. Meanwhile, his family has racked up about $40,000 in bills for travel for medical care and related costs. "There are many complications and risks associated with these transplants, and I do not think a good job is done by the doctors explaining all of them beforehand," says his wife Valarie.

Even when the risks are explained, patients aren't always prepared for what life is like postsurgery. In March, Lindsey McFarland, 26, was rolled in a wheelchair into a Cleveland Clinic press conference with her husband Blake and introduced to the world as the first successful uterus-transplant recipient in the U.S.

McFarland was born without a uterus. She and her husband were keen to start a family anyway, and so through foster care and adoption, they now have three boys, ages 20 months, 5 years and 6. While they're thrilled to be parents, McFarland never stopped wanting to give birth and maintained a five-year email correspondence with a physician studying uterus transplants. "I wanted to feel a baby move," she says of her desire to become a biological mom. "I wanted to find out the gender and pick names."

Once McFarland's 10-hour surgery was done, the plan was for her to undergo monitoring for one year before trying in vitro fertilization. At the press conference announcing her successful surgery, McFarland's voice shook with nerves. She thanked the donor's family as well as her surgical team. "I prayed that God would allow me the opportunity to experience pregnancy," she said on camera.

That evening, it was discovered she had contracted an infection, and soon she had to have the uterus removed. "It was

heartbreaking," says McFarland. "It's one of those times where you want to scream and cry, but it's really hard to grieve in a hospital room. The night I was discharged was one of the first times I really sat down and cried. I take it day by day."

It was a blow to her surgeons' hopes too. "This had been years and years in the making for many of us," says Dr. Rebecca Flyckt, an ob-gyn surgeon on the Cleveland Clinic team. "To have things initially be so promising and then have it end with removing the uterus was a real feeling of disappointment for us as well as the patient." The team is changing some of the technical aspects of how a uterus is transferred and transplanted to avoid infections in the future. They're also changing the informed-consent process, so women know that what happened to McFarland could happen to them too.

Public acceptance of procedures like this has evolved over time, but questions and skepticism remain. Ko, the surgeon who performed Manning's penis-transplant surgery at Mass General, didn't tell his own mother he was training to do it, even though it was a career high point. She found out only after seeing his picture in the newspaper. "Three years ago when we mentioned this to our colleagues, the first thing we got was a snicker," Ko says. "The second thing we got was 'You are crazy.' I think society is more accepting now. We think the world is willing to come to terms with what we are doing."

Part of the unease stems from people's discomfort with seeing a loved one's body part on someone else. Donating genitalia or other reproductive organs–which feel more like integral parts of a person's body identity than, say, a kidney–can also give donors and their loved ones pause. "Your daughter is now dead, but her uterus is transplanted, and that other person now has a baby," says Arthur Caplan, director of medical ethics at NYU Langone Medical Center, who studies the ethics of VCAs. "That's a lot of emotional and psychological baggage."

Two years ago the U.S. government added VCAs to the list of transplants covered by federal regulation, but for the time being, the more than 50% of Americans who are registered as organ donors do not automatically sign away their VCA organs. Instead, when they die, people who work for organ-procurement organizations ask families for consent.

All surgeries carry the threat of complications, and these can be especially dangerous. About 65% of face-transplant recipients have shown signs of rejection within the first year, and about half of 12 uterine transplants have failed so far. These advancements in science mean doctors and patients face a new dilemma: How much burden should a person bear for a procedure that is not lifesaving?

In hindsight, Kepner says he would not go through the double-hand-transplant surgery again. With prostheses, Kepner says, he was 75% functional, but today, he says, he feels “0%” functional. “I know that there are success stories out there, and I am thankful for those,” says his wife Valarie. “But Jeff is not one of them, and the issues that he now deals with on a daily basis are much greater than those he had when he was an amputee.” Still, Kepner does not criticize the doctors who undertook the operation. “That’s the chance you take,” he says, “and that’s the chance I took.”

Meanwhile, other transplant recipients have reported remarkable outcomes and lives that changed for the better. In Sweden, five of the nine women who have undergone uterus transplants from living donors (many of the donors are mothers or other relatives of the recipients) have given birth to healthy children.

Some experts argue that quality-of-life transplants are, in fact, lifesaving in some cases. “Surely a heart transplant is in another category, but I think there is more of a continuum than we have talked about,” says Jeffrey Kahn, director of the Johns Hopkins Berman Institute of Bioethics. “I think people who have face transplants would argue they cannot even have a life prior to

having a transplant." NYU's Caplan, who has interviewed people wanting to undergo face transplants, says the procedure can help prevent suicide. "People don't like to say it, but it's true," he says.

Hardison, the face-transplant recipient, says his children are the reason he is still alive. "I would've given up a long time ago if it wasn't for them," says the father of five. In 2001, Hardison, then a volunteer firefighter, suffered a massive burn injury to his face when he ran into a burning house and the ceiling collapsed. The fire burned off his ears, lips, eyelids and the majority of his nose.

His life took a dark turn. Over 14 years he grew depressed, lost his tire-selling business, became addicted to painkillers and split with his wife of 10 years. Though he had undergone more than 70 surgeries to improve the look and function of his face, he almost always shrouded it in a baseball cap and sunglasses. But when his doctor told him he was losing his sight as a result of living without eyelids, that was the last straw. "I hated life," he says.

On Aug. 14, 2015, Hardison underwent a 26-hour surgery to replace his face with that of a 26-year-old bike mechanic who'd been killed in a cycling accident. Though 37 face transplants had been done since the first was performed in France in 2005, Hardison's was by far the most extensive. Dr. Eduardo D. Rodriguez, head of the NYU Langone face-transplant program, told Hardison he had only a 50% chance of surviving the procedure, since no one had successfully transplanted this much face and scalp tissue before. "Everything in life has a risk," says Hardison now. "When it's your time to go, you'll go–whether you're walking down the street and get hit by a car or you're lying on the operating table."

His medical team says even more than they fear that a new organ or tissue will be rejected by the body, they fear people receiving face transplants will not identify with their new appearance or, worse, will feel altogether alienated by it. That's why before his surgery at

NYU, Hardison met with an ethicist, a psychologist and a social worker several times. Rodriguez and his colleagues visited Hardison's home in Mississippi to meet his family and friends to make sure he had good social support. "We have to ensure that patients truly understand what they are getting into," says Rodriguez. "Do they dream that someday they will look like the person they were? I'm sure they do. But they will not look like the person they used to be."

Hardison's new face is forming to his muscles and bone structure, and the swelling from the operation has significantly lessened over time. His facial expressions don't always sync with his emotions, but that will come with time. For now, walking down the street and blending into a crowd is a milestone. "I went into Macy's, and nobody stared at me," he says. "I didn't scare any kids. So I'm taking my kids to Disney World. We're a family that can do that now."

Even when things go well, life after a transplant requires vigilance. Hardison, for his part, takes three different antirejection pills twice a day. Scientists are trying to develop innovative strategies using bone-marrow cells from an organ donor to reduce rejection risk. The method has worked in some kidney transplants.

For now, quality-of-life transplants will largely be considered on a case-by-case basis. "I wouldn't stop any of these procedures, but you really have to look at them carefully," says Caplan, the NYU ethicist. For Manning, the chance to put an end to his bad luck was too good to pass up. "Right now I may be one of the only men in the world with a transplanted penis," he says. "I got it. And I am not giving it back."

Most doctors agree it will inevitably be up to people and their families to weigh their appetite for risk against their desire to feel normal. For people like Manning, that future is full of potential.

“My story has a sad beginning,” he says. “But a very exciting ending.”

RECENT QUALITY-OF-LIFE TRANSPLANTS

Breakthrough attempts at surgeries aimed at improving quality of life–such as a penis transplant, a uterus transplant and a bilateral hand transplant–have had mixed results so far in the U.S. Experts say that in some cases, that’s the price of being first.

THOMAS MANNING

After losing his penis to cancer treatment, Manning, 64, became the first man in the U.S. to receive a penis transplant. Manning’s doctors at Massachusetts General Hospital estimate that the risk that his body will reject the organ during the first year is 6% to 18%. “I am not giving it back,” says Manning.

LINDSEY MCFARLAND

Born without a uterus, McFarland, 26, became the first woman in the U.S. to receive one from a deceased organ donor. “I wanted to feel a baby move,” she says. Soon after McFarland appeared in a press conference about the surgery’s success, the uterus had to be removed because of an infection.

JEFF KEPNER

In 2009, Kepner, now 64, became the first person in the U.S. to receive a double hand transplant after losing his to an infection. From day one, his hands did not work. “That’s the chance you take,” he says, “and that’s the chance I took.” If he could, Kepner would remove the hands and use prostheses.

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The First Task for Donald Trump's New Campaign Chief: Manage the Candidate

Alex Altman is the executive features editor and deputy Washington bureau chief at TIME.

Kellyanne Conway is accustomed to dealing with difficult clients. In 2012, the Republican strategist advised Missouri Senate candidate Todd Akin, who peddled the phony notion that in cases of "legitimate rape," a woman's body has mysterious powers to prevent pregnancy. The remark helped sink the GOP's shot at controlling the Senate. And it would turn Conway into something of a specialist in helping Republican candidates refine their pitch to female voters. At a 2013 House Republican retreat, she instructed members that rape was a "four-letter word" that shouldn't ever be uttered in political campaigns.

Now the veteran pollster, 49, has another Akin-size challenge on her hands. Donald Trump named Conway his campaign manager on Aug. 17, making her the third person in as many months to lead his struggling crusade. The announcement coincided with a clear shift in Trump's behavior. He (again) started reading off teleprompters at rallies, staged a photo op in the floodplains of Louisiana, expressed regret for causing offense with past remarks and signaled he might soften his hard-line stance on immigration.

Long a fixture on cable news shows, Conway has run her own Washington firm for more than two decades and advised Trump on and off for several years. She worked on behalf of Texas Senator Ted Cruz during the 2016 GOP primary. But she has never led a presidential campaign, let alone one that requires such a dramatic makeover. Her plan for Trump this fall is to put the focus back on Hillary Clinton, who suffers from her own high disapproval ratings,

while pitching Trump as the change candidate to a restive electorate. Allies say she is up to the job. “An outsize ego is no match for Kellyanne Conway,” says GOP strategist Rick Tyler.

The first task: win Trump another look from the nearly 7 in 10 female voters who have a negative view of him. “She has thought more about the concerns of women,” says former House Speaker and Conway client Newt Gingrich, “than any other Republican I know.” The outcome is ultimately not in Conway’s hands. She can provide sage counsel. Then it’s up to the candidate to tame his own tongue.

–ALEX ALTMAN, ZEKE J. MILLER and JAY NEWTON-SMALL

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The Benefits of Friendship With Hillary Clinton

The crown prince of Bahrain is not Hillary Clinton's friend, at least not in the way most people use that word. Nor is he particularly friendly with Huma Abedin, a top Clinton deputy, or the co-founder of the Clinton Global Initiative Doug Band.

And yet for some reason, in June 2009, Band wrote an email to Abedin asking for a meeting between the Secretary of State and Salman bin Hamad bin Isa al-Khalifa. "Good friend of ours," Band said of the crown prince. Abedin, who would later work for Band's consulting firm while still drawing a public salary at the State Department, promptly set up an appointment with Clinton three days later.

At that point, Salman had already announced he would fund a scholarship program through the Clinton Initiative, to which he would commit a total of $32 million, in addition to a direct gift to the Clinton Foundation from his kingdom for more than $50,000. The State Department said at the time that Clinton and the crown prince discussed Middle East relations, and Clinton's campaign says such donations played no role in speeding the meeting at the

State Department. “Hillary Clinton never took action as Secretary of State because of donations to the Clinton Foundation,” says spokesman Josh Schwerin.

But Clinton and her staff, not to mention the staff of former President Bill Clinton, did have many friends. And with some of those friendships came privileges, and often seven-figure purse strings. A review by the Associated Press found that more than half the private individuals whom Clinton met with while at the State Department, according to publicly available records from the first half of her tenure, had donated to the foundation. That’s 85 of the 154 people outside government, not including donors like Salman, who was a foreign official.

Friendship, for the Clintons, has always had a broad definition. The Democratic nominee often describes her family’s biggest lifetime donors as her closest friends. And the feeling is often mutual. One man she calls “my dear friend,” S. Daniel Abraham, is a major donor to Clinton campaigns and the foundation, and has met frequently with both Clintons over the years to discuss his favorite cause of finding peace in Israel. In an interview with TIME, he said the millions he has given to the Clintons’ efforts do not influence their relationship. “It was what you’d think,” he said, of his meetings with her at State. “I am a friend of theirs, and they are a friend of mine.”

Having friends with financial benefits is not a crime. In the 2010 Citizens United decision, the Supreme Court ruled that both “ingratiation and access” were “not corruption,” absent other official acts resulting from donations. As a State Department spokesman put it, after the conservative group Judicial Watch forced the release of more emails through the Freedom of Information Act, “This was simply, you know, evidence of the way the process works.”

But the perks of Clinton friendship do conflict with the central promise of her campaign, to take on the corruption of Washington and fight every day on the side of working people. “Democracy can’t be just for billionaires,” she has said.

Even if Clinton is elected President, the former First Couple has decided to continue operating the Clinton Foundation, though under a new arrangement. Foreign and corporate donations will be banned, Bill Clinton will step down from its board, and the Clinton Global Initiative will stop holding annual meetings after this September. But the Clintons’ sole heir, Chelsea, is expected to remain involved, benefiting from a major fundraising effort for a foundation endowment that Hillary led in 2014.

There is no sign that a President Hillary Clinton would make adjustments to her social circle. As news of the latest emails broke, she attended a $50,000-per-person fundraiser at the Beverly Hills home of Haim Saban–whom Bill Clinton has called a “very good friend”–where she later spent the night. Saban and his wife have given more than $10 million to Clinton campaign efforts this season and more than $10 million to the foundation. Her campaign said she spoke at the event about the ways in which “everybody plays a role in creating America’s future.”

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Akhil Reed Amar: How Hillary Clinton Is Like Alexander Hamilton

Lily Rothman is managing editor at TIME. She was also the founding editor of TIME's history section.

How well do you think the average American understands the Constitution?

Not at all, alas. It's a shame because it was designed to be read. Here's an analogy: I like baseball, but baseball's a little boring unless you're into it. The Constitution is no more forbidding than baseball, but we have to get into it.

You wrote in 2008 that Hillary Clinton is to Bill Clinton as Hamilton was to Washington. Do you still think she's like him?

She's like Alexander Hamilton and, believe it or not, Martin Van Buren. Both New Yorkers, both in effect handpicked successors of

very popular two-term Presidents, both lowborn.

So who's Trump?

I don't think we've ever seen someone like Trump.

You're asking people to look to a document written by dead men for answers to today's hard questions. Why?

Because they began a story that's still unfolding. There is in the world B.C. and A.D.: before the Constitution, after the document. And the rest of the world is watching. My parents were born in undivided India, ruled by a monarch and by the Parliament that no one in India ever voted for, just like the American revolutionaries. Today, India is a billion people governing themselves democratically with a written constitution.

As a professor at Yale, you got a close look at campus unrest this year. What did you think of the protests?

The discussions that occur in college can be difficult because for many people this is the first time they're encountering folks from different neighborhoods. A huge proportion of Americans live around like-minded folks and are choosing information only from people who agree with them.

You mean on Facebook?

Yes, social media. But you go to college, and we're forcing you to encounter people who might have a different point of view. When you see a little slice of that encounter, it can look scary, but it's part of the process by which we start to talk to each other rather than past each other.

How did you feel about Ruth Bader Ginsburg's airing her views on Trump?

Here's the best defense of what she did: It's a version of civil disobedience. If you believe that Trump is an existential threat to the rule of law and the American constitutional process, then the question isn't "Why did you speak up?" but "Why didn't others?"

A movie about Loving v. Virginia, which ended antimiscegenation laws, is coming out soon. Which other Supreme Court cases would make good movies?

The modern Loving v. Virginia is called Obergefell [the marriage-equality case]. Those cases about the right to marry are great because they humanize the abstract principles of equality.

Are you saying the McCulloch v. Maryland movie would be boring?

The national bank is more abstract. I actually have written a Hollywood treatment of some of the complexities of presidential succession. I do think that could make a constitutional thriller in the tradition of Advise & Consent and Air Force One.

When you emptied your pockets so we could take your picture, you pulled out three copies of the Constitution. One wasn't enough?

People died for these words, so we should have the words literally close to our hearts. You should have more than one copy because if someone asks you a question about the Constitution, I think it's wonderful and democratic if you can give them a copy and you can read it together.

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Nigeria Wages War on “Indiscipline”

Nigeria’s President Muhammadu Buhari relaunched a controversial “war against indiscipline” program on Aug. 15, a move seen as an attempt to reset his flagging presidency. Here’s why:

STRIKE FORCE

Buhari first tackled public conduct in 1984, when he ruled the country as a military dictator. The brutal campaign saw soldiers armed with whips beat offenders for minor infractions such as being late for work or failing to wait in line properly.

BATTLE RESUMED

Officials say this version will not be so punitive. The new scheme aims to reduce social ills like corruption and violence with 170,000 enforcers, mainly volunteers. But experts say the government-backed brigade could exacerbate discontent.

MOUNTING TROUBLE

The attempt comes as Buhari’s Cabinet is accused of failing to tackle corruption or reform an ailing economy and as Islamist group Boko Haram continues to run rampant. On Aug. 23 the military reported for at least the third time the killing of leader Abubakar Shekau, a claim widely seen as propaganda. Few in Nigeria are happy that Buhari would rather wage war on indiscipline.

–TARA JOHN

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Review: The New Ben-Hur Is Mildly Exciting At Best

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

Leprosy just doesn’t have the cachet it used to. In the 1925 and 1959 film versions of *Ben-Hur*—as well as in the novel they’re based on, Lew Wallace’s stalwart 1880 Biblical epic *Ben-Hur: A Tale of the Christ*—the mother and sister of Jewish nobleman Judah Ben-Hur suffer a long and unjust imprisonment, during which they contract this fearsome, disfiguring communicable disease. When they’re finally released, they’re banished to the Valley of the Lepers, a terrible place with a terribly romantic name. That’s what literature, including the literature of movies, is for: Words and images can often draw out feelings we didn’t know we had. The Valley of the Lepers is surely no place you’d want to visit, but its name alone evokes doomy, decrepit secrets.

But Timur Bekmambetov’s new *Ben-Hur* adaptation downplays the terrible physical affliction visited upon mother Naomi and sister

Tirzah (Ayelet Zurer and Sofia Black-D'Elia). They simply look mad, their eyes betraying a kind of stock, off-their-meds wildness. Compared with leprosy, garden-variety craziness just doesn't swing. And that sums up the total squareness of this new *Ben-Hur*: In freshening up the story for a new audience, Bekmambetov (*Abraham Lincoln: Vampire Hunter*, *Night Watch*) has sucked most of the poetry from its soul, which makes it seem *more* dated rather than less. Even the dialogue has a digital-age ring to it. "What's been said about Pontius Pilate?" one character asks. "To be honest, nothing good," responds the other.

TBH, this *Ben-Hur* is so 2016 that it's likely to seem dated in 2017. Still, it isn't a complete failure. As Judah Ben-Hur, a man bent on revenge until he's transformed by grace, Jack Huston—grandson of legendary director John—has a glow of modesty about him. If he doesn't quite light up the role, at least he doesn't peacock through it. And Toby Kebbell brings just enough gloomy complexity to the role of Judah's Roman adoptive brother, the ambitious and resentful Messala. We can almost see the chip on his cape-draped shoulder.

Yet you can never be sure what this $100-million spectacle is trying to be, or exactly whom it's for. The picture, released on August 18, hasn't gotten much love from critics, and audiences haven't flocked to it, either: It made just $11.4 million on its opening weekend. Perhaps old-fashioned epics, particularly Biblical ones, are a tougher sell in an era when mutants can work box-office miracles with their superpowers. Paramount and MGM, who co-produced the film, had hoped it might find its audience among Christian filmgoers. But even though Jesus (played by Rodrigo Santoro) is more of an overt presence here than in previous adaptations, he still comes off as an afterthought. As Judah wends his way through a bazaar, a carpenter who happens to be working nearby pipes up helpfully, "Love your enemies." That's

Jesus' entrance in this Ben-Hur, and it may be his finest moment. Mostly, he's mostly just a calming hippie dude.

Unfortunately, he's no match for the horses that draw Judah's chariot, the true stars of this *Ben-Hur*. The nail-biter chariot race is the anchor of any Ben-Hur adaptation, and Bekmambetov pulls this one off with reasonable gusto. Huston and his fellow actors learned the basics of charioteering for their roles. If the sequence doesn't have the jaw-dropping, how'd-they-do-that? elegance of the race in William Wyler's 1959 version, it at least comes off as surprisingly naturalistic in these CGI-heavy times, and features many satisfying, grisly tramplings. And the four white horses who draw Judah's chariot? They're sublime in their beauty, like four matching pitchers of cream, visions of fluid, bobbing grace. They're proof that *Ben-Hur* is a story for the ages, capable of surviving even a disappointing movie interpretation. When we get sick of looking at horses, we'll know it's really all over.

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Review: Barack and Michelle’s First Date, Imagined, in Southside with You

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

No matter where you stand on the political spectrum, you’re probably hard-pressed to think of a presidential first date you’d like to see dramatized onscreen. In his modest but beautifully wrought feature debut, writer-director Richard Tanne makes the best possible choice: *Southside with You* is a vivid, imaginative portrayal of the first date between the woman then known as Michelle Robinson and the suitor who works hard to win her, the young Barack Obama.

Michelle (Tika Sumpter), a few years into her career as a lawyer at Chicago’s Sidley Austin, accepts an invitation from Barack (Parker Sawyers), a summer associate at the firm and her advisee, to attend a meeting at a Southside church: A group of citizens are trying to get a community center built for their kids, and Barack used to work with them until he decided to leave for law school. The film

opens with Michelle getting ready for this excursion, which she keeps insisting is not a date: She's fastened her hair into a tight, neat, businesslike twist, but she's also wearing a floaty orange sherbet-colored silk blouse, a nod to her future as a fashionable but fairly practical First Lady. Her parents can't help noting how much care she's taken in the presentation department, and they tease her a little. They also quiz her, as parents will, and she deflects their questions. Long after Barack has picked her up in his beater—she can see the street whizzing by through a hole in the floor—she's still deflecting.

Michelle makes the terms of this nondate clear from the minute she steps into that car. Barack agrees—and keeps agreeing—to her terms, though he uses his stealth charm to turn this potentially straightforward outing into a daylong romantic interlude that will also, as it turns out, shape the country's future. Tanne has shown Barack getting ready for this nondate as well: When we first see him, he's slouched in a chair, reading a book and smoking a cigarette—he pulls himself together and looks terrifically suave in his own way, though only later does he truly shine. He starts the nondate by taking Michelle to the Art Institute, where he impresses her with his knowledge of the artist whose work is on display there, Ernie Barnes, whose vibrant paintings capture elements of black American life in the '70s. This dazzling, surefooted young woman begins to soften toward her would-be paramour, but his work is hardly finished yet. It's only later, when Barack addresses the small but fiery assembly at the church meeting—he uses common sense and good humor to galvanize them in the face of what they believe is a lost cause—that his extraordinary leadership qualities simmer to the surface. And that's when Michelle, who comes from a proper, middle-class family, begins to see traits in this young man—raised by a single mother, and harboring little love for his deadbeat father—that distinguish him from everyone else.

Southside with You isn’t, of course, a documentary. Who really knows what this first date was like? Tanne drew on the public record and interviews, and has estimated that the general roadmap he’s drawn is “about 90 percent accurate.” But as a work of imagination inspired by fact, the film shimmers with warmth. Sawyers captures both the easy, loping rhythms of our future 44th President’s speech and the long-stride elegance of his carriage. Sumpter is equally terrific: She doesn’t quite resemble Michelle Obama, but she manifests perfectly the future First Lady’s under-the-radar determination, always tempered by empathy. As first dates go, this was a doozy. Tanne presents it as a sterling illustration of what two people can do when they face forward, together.

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Review: Edgar Ramirez Makes a Dazzling Roberto Duran in Hands of Stone

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

The story of Panamanian boxing champ Roberto Duran has a mystery wrapped deep and tight inside its glove: Why, in the eighth round of his November 1980 rematch with Sugar Ray Leonard—whom he'd defeated five months earlier in a 15-round match that had been punishing for both—did he suddenly turn away from his opponent, waving his powerhouse arms like useless noodles while (reportedly) saying, "No mas"? Why would any fighter, especially one as scrappy as Duran, walk away from such a momentous match—courting the world's ridicule and, worse, its fury?

Venezuelan director Jonathan Jakubowicz's *Hands of Stone*, a dual portrait of Duran and the superstar trainer who urged him to victory, Ray Arcel, doesn't tell us why, because no one really

knows why. Boxing, as Arcel (played by an understated, almost pensive Robert De Niro) says in the movie, is brains over brawn, and on that night, Duran's brain, as infinitely unknowable as any other, definitely called the shots.

Jakubowicz's movie is occasionally clumsy in its storytelling, but the boxing sequences, at least, crackle: Boxing movies have become the refuge for people who love the sport in theory but who can't stand how dangerously brutal it has become, and on that level, *Hands of Stone* works well enough. But the real reason to see it is for Edgar Ramirez (*Carlos*, *Joy*), who plays Duran, a cocksure fighter who could also be downright nasty outside the ring. Ramirez captures all of that, but he also digs deep to find more. The performance works as a miniature study of machismo, which can be both a show-offy radiance and a kind of shade—a safe, sheltering rock for a man to hide behind. Duran, now 65, denies ever having said, "No mas" that night. But Ramirez makes you believe he could have said it—that even a man who would come to be known as one of the greatest boxers of all time could have, in a crucial instant, faced down his own unnamable vulnerabilities and thought, *Enough*. That's the real fighting spirit, and it's there in Ramirez's eyes.

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Can Virtual Reality Help People Manage Pain?

Snowflakes fall around me as I float above a river, weaving through an icy wonderland. I toss a fish to an otter, and it shivers with glee. Then, as I exit a cave full of colorful rocks, I flow into a bright spring landscape, complete with cherry blossoms.

This trippy yet oddly relaxing simulation (officially titled COOL!) comes courtesy of DeepStream VR, a Seattle-based virtual-reality startup. But it’s no game: early research has shown that for people with chronic or acute pain, having the same experience I did can offer a much needed reprieve–not just during the treatment but for days after. “We can manipulate the experience to get the best outcome for people,” says Howard Rose, DeepStream’s co-founder and CEO.

He’s not alone in that excitement. As VR technology gets better, cheaper and more accessible–thanks in part to consumer-friendly headsets like the Oculus Rift, which debuted in March–a small but growing number of scientists and entrepreneurs are using it to treat medical conditions, including PTSD and chronic pain. The financial stakes are high: Goldman Sachs expects total revenue from the VR industry to hit $95 billion in 2025, of which over $5 billion could come from medical applications. Virtual reality could

also reshape the nature of medicine itself, enabling doctors to abandon what Rose calls “a one-pill-fits-all approach” to treatment.

Right now, though, its proponents still have a lot to prove. Although individual studies of people with chronic pain have shown that VR can offer relief, a 2014 review of 17 studies of people with acute pain revealed that relief was mostly short-lived. And for psychological conditions like social-anxiety disorder, a 2015 study showed in-person therapy worked better than VR. “I am on the fence [about VR health care] right now,” says Bernie Garrett, an associate professor at the University of British Columbia School of Nursing who is studying how VR affects chronic pain. “There are definitely some benefits, but we don’t understand what they are.”

That’s starting to change. Until recently, it cost millions to build VR labs and to conduct tests, which was too steep a price tag for most researchers. Now that the technology is more readily available, it’s a lot easier to experiment–and to gather the data necessary to draw more informed conclusions.

DeepStream is one of several for-profit startups in this space, alongside AppliedVR and Pear Therapeutics. But academics like Garrett are working hard too. At the University of Southern California, for example, researchers are virtually re-creating battle scenarios for veterans in order to treat their PTSD. It’s a more immersive version of exposure therapy, a common psychological treatment in which people talk repeatedly about traumatic events in order to process them. For patients who can’t “emotionally engage with their imagination,” VR can offer an invaluable assist, says Skip Rizzo, who’s heading the initiative at USC. “We can put people in environments that resemble what they went through, and help them go back and confront [their traumas],” he explains. “It adds to the menu of treatment options.”

It’s less clear how or why VR relieves chronic pain, since it’s a very new type of treatment. The prevailing theory is that it offers a distraction. Since humans can pay attention to only one or two things at a time, creating an environment that blocks everything out and makes them focus on a task–like, say, feeding an otter–makes it harder to focus on pain. “I’m very optimistic” about its potential, says Walter Greenleaf, who’s researching VR health care at Stanford University. Of course, immersing oneself in a virtual reality can have its own side effects, like motion sickness. During one of Garrett’s trials, a woman became so nauseated, she had to lie down for three hours to recover.

But for Ted Jones, a clinical psychologist at Pain Consultants of East Tennessee, the prospect of a new way to manage pain without pills is worth the risk. His patients have already experimented with Cool! and logged encouraging results. Now, Jones says, he’s waiting for VR treatment to become more widely accepted, so insurance companies will cover it. “We are in the heart of opioid-abuse land down here in Southern Appalachia,” he explains. “A non-opioid alternative is just what we need.”

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This Just In

Julia Zorthian is a reporter at TIME. She covers general news.

A roundup of new and noteworthy insights from the week's most talked-about studies:

1 BREADWINNING IS GOOD FOR WOMEN AND BAD FOR MEN

A study from the University of Connecticut, which analyzed Bureau of Labor Statistics data, found that acting as the primary breadwinner in a family has a negative impact on the mental and physical health of men. For women, however, there was a positive psychological effect.

2 LOW EXPECTATIONS MAY AFFECT BREAST-CANCER TREATMENT

A study in the journal Annals of Oncology found that women with low expectations during hormonal therapy for breast cancer experienced twice as many side effects from the treatment as those with less negative thoughts.

3 DOGS MAY PREFER PRAISE OVER FOOD

In a study published in Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, researchers who analyzed canine behavior and neural responses found that most dogs liked getting praise from their owners just as much as they liked getting food, if not more so.

–J.Z.

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Quick Talk with Clea DuVall

Eliza Berman is a senior editor at TIME. She has covered movies, TV, music, books, and theater.

When did this story come to you?

I was a person who thought I knew what was best for everyone else, but I had this epiphany where I realized the more I'm focusing on other people's lives, the less I'm looking at myself. That led me on this journey of being a less harsh critic to the people around me.

You've talked about the value of therapy. Did your own therapy influence the screenplay?

Oh, 100%. I was going to therapy and reading so many books, trying to educate myself on what was going on with me but also what might be going on with people around me to gain a perspective different from my own. That helped me create these three-dimensional characters having a very authentic emotional experience.

Your character had a romantic relationship with co-star Natasha Lyonne's character in But I'm a Cheerleader in 1999, and again in this film. Has Hollywood changed a lot since then?

For sure. When we made But I'm a Cheerleader, the ratings board gave us an NC-17, and it's the most tame movie. With this movie, it's not even a big deal. The fact that there are gay characters and it's not the lead story shows how far we've come. That's important, normalizing something that is very normal but to some people still seems exotic.

Have you caught the directing bug?

Absolutely. Being an actor is a great job, and I'm so grateful that I've had such a long career. But I'm not as interesting to myself as I once was. I'm so much more interested in other actors and so excited about being responsible for coming up with solutions to the many problems that happen throughout the day on a film set. I felt so engaged. I want to do that all the time.

–ELIZA BERMAN

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A New Wave of Miniseries Lends Clarity to a Muddled Medium

The Emmys have never been particularly hospitable to the new. Part of that is just an awards-show problem, the consequence of a group of thousands of Hollywood types reverting to the familiar choices on their ballots. At this year's Emmy ceremony (to air Sept. 18 on ABC), two of the seven Best Comedy nominees (*black-ish* and *Master of None*) are first-timers, but all five returning nominees have been nominated every year they were eligible (including a fifth consecutive nod for likely winner *Veep* and an astounding seventh for the aging *Modern Family*). The Best Drama list saw The Americans fill a prestige-cable slot left empty by the departed *Mad Men*, while *Mr. Robot* got its first nod, but the rest feels … stale. Sure, *Game of Thrones* is TV's signature hit, but continued Emmy love for *House of Cards*, *Homeland* and *Downton Abbey* reveals a grievous unimaginativeness.

Meanwhile, on what has traditionally been Emmy's undercard, intriguing things are happening. While there's drudgery throughout both TV-series categories, the Best Limited Series field–rewarding what most viewers call miniseries–is the year's richest, filled with the shows TV fans actually spent the season talking about.

The almost certain winner is FX's *The People v. O.J. Simpson*, the first installment of a planned franchise, *American Crime Story*, that will refresh each year with a new premise and characters. (Season 2 is to be about *Hurricane Katrina*.) The O.J. series isn't just better than the bulk of the Best Drama field; what it does better reveals why miniseries are at TV's bleeding edge.

The *People v. O.J. Simpson* had a discrete story–the legal aftermath of the killing of two innocents, concluding with the acquittal of their alleged murderer. It had 10 episodes to weave its tale. Tight constraints were, as is so often the case, the perfect symbiotic partner to lavishness. The series colored within clearly defined lines but did so using the most vivid of hues. The visuals, in the hands of just three directors, managed a confident cohesion–favoring sweeping camera movement across the courtroom and tight closeups–that made most long-running shows look disjointed by comparison. And the performances (including those of Emmy nominees Sarah Paulson, Courtney B. Vance and Cuba Gooding Jr.) were pitched at a zestily melodramatic level that the actors couldn't have sustained over several seasons without subjecting viewers to emotional exhaustion.

That's the great strength of the limited series, one first observed when HBO lured movie-industry talent to the lushly trashy first season of *True Detective*. A short-running show can race much harder than a long one in pursuit of deeper resonance. Every multiseason series will have down episodes; on USA right now, *Mr. Robot*, still figuring out what it wants to say after a first season that took swings perhaps too big to be viable long-term, is having a down season. Limited series are all-killer, no-filler. They're as punchy as a truncated social-media update, and perfectly suited for the era of the binge. You can experience the same emotional arc that the very best dramas spend years assiduously building, all in an afternoon.

Every moment of *O.J.* was carefully chosen, and each episode contemplated the trial from a different, provocative angle (from gender politics to the racial makeup of the jury). On fellow Best Limited Series nominees *Fargo* and *American Crime* (both shows that reboot to tell new tales of malfeasance each season), individual cases come to implicate and destroy a vast cast of characters in a manner that proceeds with the grim logic of a morality play. *The Night Manager*, a nominee that aired on AMC after an overseas run on the BBC, delivers its spy story with panache and assurance, tying up all loose ends after six installments. And the flawed History update of *Roots* amps up the immediacy and viscerality of its images, making the most potent possible use of its limited time with the viewer. All this proves that the balance between TV series and miniseries has changed. The genre that networks once used to bid for cultural cachet (from the original *Roots* to *Holocaust* to *The Thorn Birds* to *Angels in America*) is now the one that feels most vitally alive.

And those are just the nominees. The medium is booming so much that *American Horror Story*, the show that helped make clear how a short run could enable bold storytelling, missed out on a nomination this year for the first time since it was eligible. I'd add another should-have-been to the nominees list: Starz's *The Girlfriend Experience*, a drama that demonstrates remarkable adherence to a chilly vision of sex and surveillance generated by a pair of writer-directors. With ever more viewing options and a limited amount of time to watch television, it's nice to know you're in the hands of a guiding intelligence that knows what it's doing.

Homeland, *House of Cards* and *Downton Abbey* aren't disappointing nominees because they're "bad" (they're not). But all have aged in that TV-drama way where you wonder if anyone involved remembers what the plan was back in Season 1. Their turns–Frank Underwood choosing his wife as a running mate; Carrie Mathison going to Kabul, Berlin and, soon, New York City–

don’t feel calculated to bring us joy or astonishment or new insight. They feel calculated to keep the shows churning for one season longer. The circumstances change, but consequences are absent.

The vogue for miniseries makes TV drama, focused on self-perpetuation at the expense of actual change, seem obsolete. I really like Best Drama nominee *Better Call Saul*. The *Breaking Bad* spin-off’s first two seasons consistently surprised me with a willingness to probe unexpected angles on what could have been a simple story of a crooked lawyer. But telling people to watch it does not–and cannot–come with an assurance that it’ll stay great.

This understanding that even the best shows may decline has been part of TV watching since the beginning, but it is now becoming unfashionable. A culture in which on-demand, bespoke entertainment experiences have conditioned us to expect perfection coexists uneasily with a business whose networks and streaming services, hungry for content, keep shows around long past their creative peak. Miniseries reward both our appreciation for the well-crafted story and our unwillingness to commit in an era of too many choices.

The optimistic view of the miniseries’ rise is that we’re in the midst of a genuinely exciting reorganization of how TV works. As recently as 2011, the best-case scenario for an Emmy-ratified miniseries–like the tartly class-conscious *Downton Abbey*–was to have the business side decide you had more and more stories to tell, even at the expense of what had once been a clear vision. Today a miniseries hit is able to keep all of its ideas intact while working toward another perfectly formed set of episodes. That each set will leave glutted TV viewers feeling something to which we’ve grown unaccustomed–the desire for more–is precisely the point.

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Milestones

DIED

Toots Thielemans, 94, Belgian jazz harmonica player who collaborated with music greats from Benny Goodman to Paul Simon. His playing was featured on the opening theme of Sesame Street and on the soundtracks for Midnight Cowboy (1969) and The Getaway (1972).

Lou Pearlman, 62, former manager of boy bands like ‘N Sync, Backstreet Boys and LFO. He died in jail, having spent his final years incarcerated for a Ponzi scheme that defrauded investors of an estimated $300 million.

CLOSED

The website Gawker, after its parent company was sold to Univision. The site was created in 2002 as a media gossip blog and became known for its mixture of salacious tittle-tattle and in-depth reporting. Its parent company, Gawker Media, declared bankruptcy in June after the site lost a $140 million privacy lawsuit over a sex tape it published featuring former wrestling star Hulk Hogan.

ANNOUNCED

By the Obama Administration that the federal government would phase out the use of privately operated prisons. A memo from the Justice Department said the 13 private prisons contracted by the government “do not provide the same level of correctional services, programs and resources” as those in the public sector.

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A Taste of a Carless Future

BOGOTÁ

Since 1976, Colombia’s capital has welcomed millions to walk or bike through 75 miles of car-free roads every Sunday (as shown above). The event, called Ciclovía, led cities in Mexico, Chile, Brazil and Ecuador to hold similar days.

SAN FRANCISCO

Inspired by Ciclovía, the City by the Bay has shut streets on select Sundays throughout the year since 2008 for cycling, yoga and other activities. It’s one of at least 65 U.S. cities to stage similar events.

OSLO

The Norwegian capital wants to take the Ciclovía concept to the next level: last year it unveiled plans to become the first European city to ban cars completely from its center by 2019.

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For the Record

‘What the hell do you have to lose?’

Donald Trump, trying to court black voters–among whom he’s polling at less than 1% in many states–by claiming that things could not get any worse than they are right now

BORDER PATROL

1,500

The number of rafters and boaters in the St. Clair River who were blown from Michigan into Canada by high winds on Aug. 21; Canadian police brought them back to the U.S. by bus

22

The number of months NASA had lost contact with the STEREO-B spacecraft, which is studying the sun; contact was restored on Aug. 21

‘Maybe we’ll just … decide to separate from the United Nations.’

Rodrigo Duterte, Philippine President, after the U.N. criticized his antidrug campaign as a human-rights violation; since Duterte took office on June 30, there have been more than 650 police killings and thousands of unexplained arrests

‘All of us are holding our breath and crossing our fingers.’

Cindy Lerner, mayor of Pinecrest, Fla., speaking of concerns that Zika may spread from two other locations in Miami-Dade County, where officials have identified transmission of the virus

‘I overexaggerated that story.’

Ryan Lochte, U.S. Olympic swimmer, admitting he lied about getting robbed at gunpoint in Rio; shortly after, he lost endorsement deals with Speedo and Ralph Lauren

Researchers confirmed that a Bosnian pine in Greece is the oldest European tree ever found, at 1,075 years of age. Here’s how that compares with the record holders for other continents:

North America

5,062

South America

3,622

Asia

2,217

Europe

1,075

years

‘Thank you all. Especially those of you who never let me forget I had to finish. Which is basically every one of y’all.’

Frank Ocean, musician, writing to fans after releasing his second album, Blonde, on Aug. 20, ending more than four years of anticipation

SOURCES: BBC; NBC NEWS; NEW YORK TIMES; ROCKY MOUNTAIN TREE-RING RESEARCH

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Where Rio Goes from Here

Sean Gregory is a senior sports correspondent at TIME. His work has been cited in the annual Best American Sports Writing anthology nine times. His stories have won awards from the U.S. Basketball Writers Association, the American Academy of Orthopaedic Surgeons, and his work was named a finalist for Deadline Club and Mirror awards for excellence in magazine writing and reporting on media, respectively.

More than two weeks after thousands of athletes from every corner of the world poured into Rio de Janeiro's Maracanã Stadium to open the first Olympics on South American soil, fireworks flew over the arena to bring the 2016 Games to a close. The 16 days in between were a heady mix of awe-inspiring achievements and thrilling contests, with a dollop of international scandal.

No one was more successful than Team USA, which racked up 121 medals, 46 of them gold, almost double the haul of second-place Great Britain. The host nation didn't fare as well (its 19 medals put it in 13th place), but Brazil did win what it wanted most: gold in men's soccer. That triumph was a highlight of a Games that will

also be remembered for the rise of young stars like Simone Biles and Katie Ledecky and the curtain calls of legends Usain Bolt and Michael Phelps.

Their feats were briefly nudged aside by the strange saga of Ryan Lochte, whose story about being held up at gunpoint—-soon revealed as a fiction—-cast a pall over the Games and may well end his decorated career. More important, however, is what the legacy will be for the host city. The Olympics spurred a number of infrastructure projects in Rio, including a revitalized port and a $3 billion subway line, but the cost and utility for a city so financially strapped and profoundly segregated is unclear. Whether the gamble pays off for residents, like the boy at right, will be the truest measure of success.

–SEAN GREGORY/RIO DE JANEIRO

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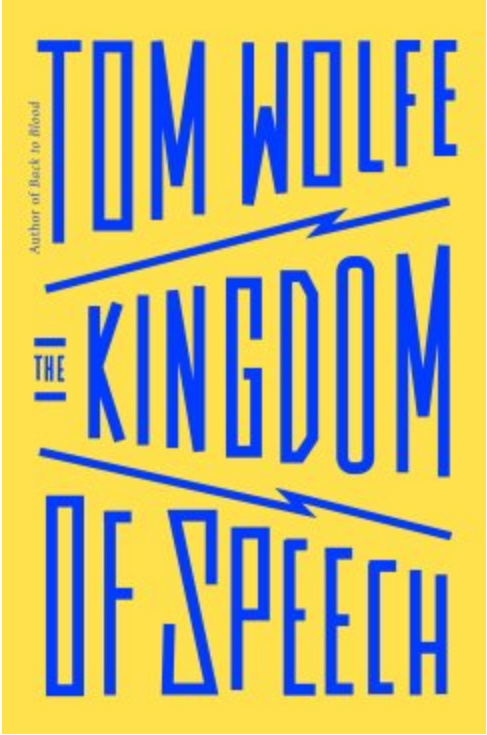
Talk May Be Cheap, But It's Humanity's Best Asset

Hopper is a former Ideas Editor for TIME.



In *The Kingdom of Speech*, Tom Wolfe offers an analytical history of humankind's struggle to understand the origins of what he calls its "superpower": speech. In Wolfe's telling, the often dry, esoteric realm of academia is rife with coups, Martians and disease. And the driving conflict is the power struggle over the legacies of Charles Darwin and MIT linguist Noam Chomsky, the intellectuals who claimed to best understand man's special ability.

Each one sought to answer how we came to possess speech. Darwin theorized that humans learned it from birdsong, while Chomsky believes we have a special organ, evidenced by the common structure of oral communication. The two have dominated how we think of language for a century and a half.

Yet for all their effort, Chomsky himself confessed that the origins of language remain unknowable. This delights Wolfe. He depicts Darwin as a sickly man of privilege who conjured ideas by sitting indoors and staring at his dog, while the 87-year-old Chomsky is an air-conditioning addict who cites hypothetical alien anthropologists to confirm his notions–and can manipulate language yet not grasp the thing itself.

What makes their failure sweetest for Wolfe is that he believes he's found the truth. He declares that speech is not an attribute but an artifact, a tool crafted by humans that is now so mighty, it makes them stronger than any other species. To Wolfe, speech constitutes a kingdom all its own–beyond that of animals.

Wolfe, still a master at using language, is another claimant for the throne. *The Kingdom of Speech* is best read, then, with Wolfe not just as a narrator-historian but as a character. One who, after critiquing theorists who rule from insulated rooms, depicts himself in that exact setting for his book's final vision.

—NATE HOPPER

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Pop Chart

LOVE IT

Kanye West wrote a poem about McDonald's for a magazine delivered alongside Frank Ocean's new album. Among the best stanzas:

'The salad bar and the ketchup made a band/Cus the French fries had a plan.'

Rihanna took a photo with a giant headless statue of herself at the Berlin Biennale for Contemporary Art.

J.K. Rowling plans to release three new collections of Harry Potter short stories on her interactive fan site Pottermore in September.

Panda Express may introduce a hybrid utensil called the Chork–a tweezer-like chopsticks-fork combination.

Pizza Hut U.K. debuted a pizza box that turns into functional DJ turntables, complete with a working mixer and controls.

Zac Efron flew to Rio to surprise one of his biggest fans: Olympic champion gymnast Simone Biles.

Time's weekly take on what popped in culture

LEAVE IT

The iconic Playboy Mansion in L.A. sold for $100 million, roughly half its asking price.

Pita Taufatofua, the Tonga flag bearer who became a viral sensation after walking shirtless during Rio's opening ceremonies, lost his

first (and only) match of Olympic taekwondo.

A British man stole money earmarked for his best friend’s bachelor party and faked having cancer to garner sympathy; he was sentenced to 20 months in prison.

Justin Bieber deleted his Instagram account after getting a slew of negative comments on photos featuring model Sofia Richie.

The world’s largest aircraft–the helium-filled Airlander 10, which is 302 ft. long–crash-landed during its second test flight in England.

Hostess is now selling frozen deep-fried Twinkles at Walmart, and they’re not as caloric as you’d expect; each has 220 calories.

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You’ll Cry Until You Laugh at Amy Schumer’s New Book

Eliana Dockterman is a correspondent at TIME. She covers culture, society, and gender, including topics from blockbuster movies to the #MeToo movement to how the pandemic pushed moms out of the workplace.

Amy Schumer’s The Girl With the Lower Back Tattoo covers a lot of territory. There are funny anecdotes–about sex, about shoplifting, about drinking–but the overall tone is bittersweet. While many celebrity memoirs read like raucous meditations on the performing life, Schumer’s tests the bounds of dark humor. She has struggled with her father’s physical deterioration from multiple sclerosis, abusive relationships and a hefty dose of sexism.

Her parents influenced her worldview: her father was too honest, sometimes to the point of cruelty; her mother was so upbeat that she denied when things went amiss. Her mother had an affair with the father of Schumer’s best friend, which split up her parents. (Each married three times.) Later, Schumer endured an abusive relationship and a sexual encounter she describes as “nonconsensual.”

Schumer’s stories of casual misogyny as she climbed the comedy ladder wind up being among the more lighthearted tales. Her conclusion: humor is largely responsible for getting her through it all, though as a reader you might find it difficult to laugh.

–ELIANA DOCKTERMAN

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The Bright Side of Darker Emotions

David is the author of Emotional Agility

It's natural to want to be happy all the time. But it's telling that most of what many consider to be our seven basic emotions–joy, anger, sadness, fear, surprise, contempt and disgust–reflect the dark side of the human experience. These emotions are still with us because they've helped us survive through several million years of evolution, and they are an integral part of what makes us human.

It's troubling, then, that so many of us try to avoid them. We use default behaviors that we hope can deflect or disguise them. We settle deeply into them, refusing to let them go. Or we attempt to ignore them entirely through cynicism, irony or gallows humor, refusing to admit anything in life is worth taking seriously. As Nietzsche once said, loosely translated, "A joke is an epitaph for an emotion." Or as Taylor Swift, that more contemporary philosopher, said, "Shake it off."

Whatever we may think we're accomplishing, these strategies don't serve our health or our happiness. When we don't go directly to the source of what's causing an emotion, we miss the ability to really deal with what's causing our distress, and we lose our ability to be fully engaged with the world around us. Instead of trying to push negative emotions aside, we should accept them as a useful–though sometimes uncomfortable–part of our lives.

Adapted from the forthcoming book Emotional Agility: Get Unstuck, Embrace Change, and Thrive in Work and Life

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Europeans Cooling on NATO

Donald Trump has called NATO “obsolete,” threatening in July to renege on the U.S. commitment to protect allies under attack. Some leading figures in Europe also question the alliance’s value:

JEREMY CORBYN

The leader of the U.K.’s opposition Labour Party said on Aug. 18 he wouldn’t aid NATO allies under attack if elected Prime Minister.

BEPPE GRILLO

The founder of Italy’s antiestablishment Five Star Movement wrote in May that NATO pandered to Washington’s “strategic designs.”

PABLO IGLESIAS

The leader of Spain’s left-wing Podemos party has long called for a referendum on NATO membership.

MARINE LE PEN

The far-right National Front party leader wants France to withdraw from NATO and has called for a better relationship with Russia.

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‘Smart’ Tattoos

Julia Zorthian is a reporter at TIME. She covers general news.

Forget smartphones and watches. DuoSkin, a new product from Microsoft and the MIT Media Lab, can turn your epidermis into a touch pad. Or a remote. Made with naturally conductive gold leaf, DuoSkin places a technological interface directly on your body. One potential application would include a Bluetooth-like chip so wearers could sync their temporary tattoo to a music system, then swipe it to change volume. Another version changes colors. The process is designed so people can customize both form and function for a tattoo that lasts only a day. The goal, says lead researcher Cindy Hsin-Liu Kao, is to create technology that’s as personal as lotion or makeup, so “it really blends into the wearer’s identity.”

–Julia Zorthian

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The Hidden History of Books

That a book looks and works as it does is an easy thing to take for granted, but it took a thousand disruptions over the course of millennia to make those bound objects what they are. In his new history of the book, written in a moment when those analog objects have an uncertain future, author Keith Houston traces the evolutions of writing, illustrating and papermaking from the ancient world to today. The attendant tales in The Book–of warring Greeks, backstabbing Chinese courtesans, of religion, pride, domination, failure and ingenuity–prove that the book's story is a reflection of human beings too. As Houston notes amid his explanation of how written language came to be: "The letters in this book are the offspring of ancient Egyptian writing, filtered through 4,000 years of human history." Are e-books the end of the story? "Yes," Houston says. "And also no. And also maybe."

–KATY STEINMETZ

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What You Said About …

INTERNET TROLLS

Joel Stein's Aug. 29 cover story on the rise of Internet trolling, from the alt-right in particular, sparked discussions everywhere from Fox News to the New York Observer to Twitter, where Andrew Stroehlein observed, "We're not just in danger of losing the Internet to hate but of losing democracies to it too." Sheldon Prial of Goose Creek, S.C., a World War II veteran, wrote that trolling reminded him of the "hate stirred up by the Nazi party." To combat the abuse, Monique Bondeux, who called the piece "chilling," suggested boycotting affected social-media sites, while Peter Guerin of Hadley, N.Y., advocated the introduction of new legislation "to reflect this frightening reality … before more people are hurt."

SENIORS AND STEIN

"Was this written tongue-in-cheek, or were you serious? Either way, it was not the least bit funny." That rebuke came from L. Kathleen Geesey, "67 and proud of it," on the subject of another Aug. 29 piece by Joel Stein, a humor column suggesting older voters should be banned from the booths because of "poor," nonprogressive voting patterns. Tom Mader of Walnut Creek, Calif., called Stein "an excellent writer" in need of schooling: "I'm sure his father has taken him out to the woodshed," he wrote, adding that seniors have time to discuss complex issues while "youngsters are so distracted with making a living, getting ahead, overeating, overdrinking and making a lot of noise that understandably they often come up with foolish ideas and idiotic decisions."

GOT GAME?

TIME's tech team rated 150 video games across four decades, from classic arcade fare to recent console hits. Among our picks for the 50 best (which you can find at time.com/bestgames): Tetris (No. 1), the addictive block-stacking game that has enthralled fans since its arrival in 1984, and the 1982 Pac-Man spin-off Ms. Pac-Man (No. 5), which obsoleted its mate with smarter ghosts and on-the-move fruit bonuses.

WILD PICS

Aug. 25 marks the 100th anniversary of the U.S. National Park Service. Less well known is the work done decades earlier that helped bring about such an achievement: a series of 1861 photos of Yosemite by Carleton Watkins. The shots thrilled Ralph Waldo Emerson and helped push Abraham Lincoln to sign a 1864 bill setting aside the land for public use. View Watkins' images at time.com/watkins

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Frank Ocean’s New Look Could Last

Singer-songwriter Frank Ocean’s legend only grew as he dragged his feet on a follow-up to Channel Orange, his Grammy-winning 2012 collection of stretched-out bummers and tender love songs. But in the late hours of Aug. 18, Ocean released Endless, a “visual album,” via Apple Music. The 45-minute black-and-white film depicts Ocean sawing, painting and ultimately building a spiral staircase, set to gauzy soul that has a deliberately sketchlike feel. Endless serves as a rebuke to those who had criticized Ocean’s scant output: making music is work, even if the labor behind it isn’t as visible as carpentry.

Two days later, newsstands in four cities were taken over by copies of Boys Don’t Cry, a 360-page magazine of his assemblage. The oversize publication, which was given away gratis, contains highly stylized photography, poetry and essays written by Ocean, a fable-slash-poem about the menu at McDonald’s by hip-hop provocateur Kanye West and, perhaps most important, a CD containing a new album, titled Blonde.

Blonde, which was also released (with a different track list) through Apple on Aug. 20, is the full-color realization of Endless's monochrome sketching. Ocean's silk-smooth voice commands tracks like the sumptuous ballad "Pink + White" and the tender "Self Control." Moody strings and pillowy keyboards swell while smaller sonic details receive meticulous attention; it's a fussiness that contrasts with his abstract lyrics. Andre 3000's lightning-fast, pathos-heavy verse on "Solo (Reprise)" gives the album a bracing jolt right at its midpoint, but for the most part, the mood is hazily contemplative. He may be perceived as a confident auteur, but even Ocean can get lost in his lofty aspirations.

Whether an increasingly distracted listening public will keep Blonde in rotation once the novelty of its release wears off remains to be seen. Still, there aren't many artists who could pull off a stunt like Ocean's. The vigils kept before Endless's arrival suggest that he might be the rare artist to outlast 2016's blink-and-you'll-miss-it release cycle.

–MAURA JOHNSTON

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